

Lobos Win 3-2 Thanks To UTEP Error

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Inexperience proved to be the University of Texas at El Paso's downfall Friday afternoon against the University of New Mexico.

A single mental mistake cost the Miners a 3-2 Western Athletic Conference decision to the Lobos at Dudley Field.

With the score tied at one apiece and a runner on first in the fifth inning with no outs, UTEP second baseman Orlando Cordova elected not to charge a high bouncer hit toward him.

Instead, the sophomore, who has filled in all season long for regular second baseman Art Bravo, backpeddled on Mike Delmonico's bouncer and the ball took a high hop into right-center field for a single.

An out later, Lobo catcher Robert Bartell slammed a double off the right-center field fence, which scored what proved to be the winning run.

"Instead of coming in on the grounder, Orlando backed up and that was the turning point in the game," said UTEP Coach Andy Cohen after his Miners dropped their seventh consecutive WAC game without any victories. "But he's only a sophomore and he won't make the same mistake again."

UTEP scored the initial run of the game in the first inning as Bob Alsup led off with a double down the left field line, moved up on a grounder and scored when Rusty Kennedy also got an opposite field hit to left.

New Mexico tied the game in the third when, with two outs, Steve Muccio was hit by a Jerry Walker pitched and scored on the second of two straight singles by Delmonico and Randy Rima respectively.

Walker and Lobo starter Bruce Barber remained locked in the pitcher's duel until the fifth when UNM bunched four hits for its two runs.

The Miners also scored their final run in

the bottom half of the frame as Sal Flores walked, moved to second on an error and over to third to load the bases with no outs when Cordova pushed a bunt past the pitcher's mound.

An infield ground out off Keith Dwinell's bat scored Flores but Kennedy grounded into a doubleplay which killed UTEP's rally.

"We had the chances to win it," said Cohen. "Our hitters just didn't come through."

The Miners' next scoring threat was in the bottom of the ninth as Terry Dillingham and Steve Anson opened UTEP's last chance with singles.

Two short fly balls followed by an opposite field line drive by Alsup which was caught on the dead run by UNM's left fielder John Cifelli ended UTEP's hopes for a conference triumph.

Both teams concluded their three-game series at noon Saturday at Dudley Field with a doubleheader.